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ORIGINAL ARTICLE

Emerging Resources of China's Soft Power: A Case Study of Cambodian Participants from Chinese Higher Education Programs

Kejin Zhu[1,2] · **Rui Yang**[1]

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Abstract
Along with its unprecedented economic rise over the past several decades, debates about China's soft power push have become heated. Yet, consensus on what exactly constitutes China's soft power has not been reached. Findings of how resources of Chinese soft power play their roles in the national strategy for global rise are conflicting and lacking empirical rigor. In a much-altered context of China's recent grand initiatives, the prism of higher education and the region of Southeast Asia both are uniquely significant for interpreting soft power agenda of China. This article aims to capture the recent changes in China's soft power through a case study analysing the experiences and perceptions of Cambodian participants from China's higher education programs covering language training, educational development aid, student mobility, and institution/program partnerships. The evidence identifies four emerging resources of Chinese soft power: contemporary life appeal, advancement in science and technology, STEM (science, technology, engineering, and mathematics) education reputation, and economic development model. It further highlights the Belt and Road Initiative as a stimulus for amplifying the influence of the Chinese development model in Southeast Asia, whereas China's domestic coordination of different players and an ideal mix of soft power resources still have not been formulated.

Keywords Soft power · China · Higher education · Belt and Road Initiative · Southeast Asia · Cambodia

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Introduction

The literature on Chinese soft power has proliferated as China becomes a major global economic player. Yet, there has been no consensus on what exactly constitutes China's soft power (Blanchard and Lu, 2012). Most discussions adopt Nye's (2004) three-resource conceptualisation of culture, political values, and diplomacy to look at China's soft-power endeavours with contradictory findings of whether and how China's recognised attractions play their roles. A small number of studies have suggested development model, international image, and economic temptation as extra resources of Chinese soft power. Few pundits assess Chinese soft power wielding by examining China's public diplomacy embedded in its establishment of Confucius Institutes (CI) and recruitment of international students. Furthermore, while plenty of investigations evaluates the efficacy and mechanism of China's soft power exercise using opinion polls and document analysis, empirical studies are much lacking in terms of emerging resources of Chinese soft power in the context of China's new foreign policies and initiatives for regional connectivity.

In a much-altered context of major global events and China's grand initiatives including the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), both higher education and Southeast Asia are uniquely significant for China's soft power agenda (Yang, 2018). As Yang (2007) reminds that China has employed international higher education programs in an unprecedented way to uplift its cultural status, it is valuable to further probe into comprehensive approaches to China's 'outward-oriented' higher education internationalisation (Wu, 2019), including international students' enrolment, expansion of CIs, development assistance in the educational sector, and institution/program partnerships.

Since 2016, Southeast Asian students have become the largest group of international students in China (Tan, 2018). The total number of Southeast Asian students in China reached 98,823 in 2018, accounting for 20.08% and nearly tripled that in 2008.[1] Until 2020, 39 CIs and 34 Confucius Classrooms have scattered in ten Southeast Asian countries (Chen, 2020). Higher education aid is traditionally unfolded in China's enormous amount of scholarships for degree students, short-term and long-term training programs for officials and professionals, and school building projects such as the China-funded University of Kratie in Cambodia (Xinua News, 2018); 36 Sino-ASEAN (The Association of Southeast Asian Nations) joint programs in the form of "3+1" "2+2" or "2+1" had been running (Wen, 2016). Even three branch campuses of Chinese universities had already been established in Southeast Asia (He and Wilkins, 2019).

With the economic and political ascendance of Southeast Asia in the worldwide arena, it is increasingly urgent for China to build a more positive image in this region. To some extent, China's higher educational paradigm mirrors its tactics in

[1] The total numbers of Southeast Asian students in China in 2008 and in 2018 are based on authors' own calculation with the data retrieved from *Statistics Book of International Students Studying in China* (in Chinese) (Department of International Cooperation and Exchanges of Ministry of Education of China, 2008, 2018).

soft power agenda to harmonise the periphery. Cambodia is chosen as the field site due to its geostrategic significance for China among Southeast Asian neighbours. Beijing has long been tightening its economic, political, and socio-cultural ties with Cambodia, particularly after the launch of the BRI in 2013, to win over Cambodia's cooperation in international and regional issues including the "One China" policy and the South China Sea disputes (Kung, 2015).

This article aims to identify any emerging resources of China's soft power and explore whether and how those emerging resources contribute to China's soft power penetration in this region. Based on empirical data gathered from Cambodian participants of Chinese higher education programs, it intends to capture the dynamics of Chinese soft power components, especially with the recent influence of BRI. In the following of this article, a literature review on China's indices of soft power and educational soft power will be presented first. Then, the theoretical framework and methodology employed in this study will be elaborated. A detailed report of major findings together with discussions will be at the end.

Literature Review

Debates on Resources of Chinese Soft Power

The tripartite approach of soft power set out by Nye (2004) is political values, culture, and foreign policy. When observing China, however, both Western and Chinese analysts have focused excessively on cultural and diplomatic efforts. As for cultural resources, they usually refer to Chinese civilisation (Cho and Jeong, 2008; Huang and Ding, 2006), especially its splendid arts, traditions, and food culture. He and Wilkins (2019) summarise that necessity of Chinese language and Chinese cultural heritage are the two most influencing resources of China's soft power in Southeast Asia. Commentators of diplomacy tend to evaluate China's flagship foreign policies including 'win-win', 'peaceful rise', 'community with a shared future', its active participation in international regimes, and the latest aid approaches under BRI. However, their conclusions are often conflicting. To some, China has developed a benign and responsible reputation through its diplomatic savvy, distinct donor logic, and partnership model (DeLisle, 2010; Ding, 2008; King, 2014). Others suspect its profit-seeking intentions behind its no-strings-attached aid (Cho and Jeong, 2008; Huang and Ding, 2006).

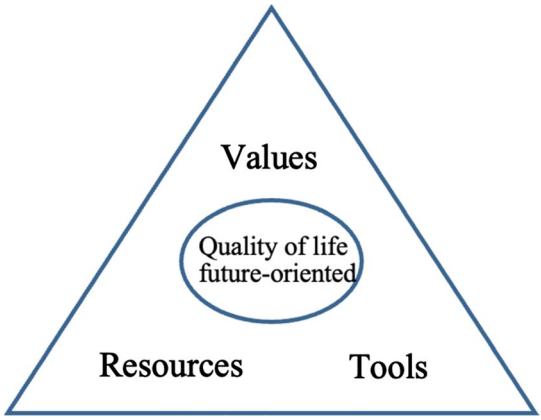
As the third primary index of soft power, however, China's political values have not been sufficiently elucidated. Adopting a Western lens, critics often argue that the authoritarian political system is a liability (Barker, 2017; Huang, 2013), undermining the appeal of China's political institutions. The Beijing Consensus is thus vulnerable due to its heavy reliance on "perspiration rather than inspiration" (Gill and Huang, 2006, 27). Yet, having demonstrated an alternative path, China's economic miracle still enables latecomers to rethink the interrelation between development economics and political freedom. Disciples of the China model have spread over Southeast Asia, South Asia, the Middle East, Africa, and Latin America (Li, 2018). Therefore, in some people's eyes,

this pragmatic development model is China's most influential political value and has enhanced Chinese soft power to some extent (Glaser and Murphy, 2008; Liang, 2012; Men, 2007).

Other resources are also in dispute. While many view the Beijing Consensus as part of Chinese political values, some insist that China's economic development model should be treated as an independent element of its soft power (Cho and Jeong, 2008; Li and Worm, 2011; Men, 2007), as it encapsulates both political and economic paradigms and challenges the dominant Washington Consensus of liberal democratic and neo-liberal bases (Breslin, 2011). Indeed, Nye (2006) admits that an economic development model could become a significant resource of soft power (Wuthnow, 2008). Debates continue despite acknowledgements of the Chinese alternative. Criticism concentrates on the shadows of the model including corruption, unsustainable development, and pollution.

As Nye (2004) elucidates, institutions contribute to a country's soft power through advancing its values and shaping international rules. China's meticulous construction of its soft power has indeed incorporated various institutions. Shambaugh (2015) analyse that the economic institutions proposed by China, including the New Development Bank, the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, and the Free Trade Area of the Asia-Pacific, have not brought China soft power due to its authoritarian political system. Others are inclined to agree that academic institutions such as CIs and universities have been piloted as state-sponsored cultural diplomacy to heighten China's soft power but still encountered objections towards CIs' potential interference with academic freedom (Gauttam et al., 2021; Pan, 2013; Song, 2017; Yang, 2010). China's international image is another additional component of soft power, encompassing the behaviours of the Chinese government, companies, and people (Li and Worm, 2011; Men, 2007). Moreover, economic strength could be converted into soft power when used as a temptation rather than coercion (Nye, 2006). China's economic levers (Kurlantzick, 2007) and temptation (Li and Worm, 2011), as other potential sources of Chinese soft power, lure other states through non-conditional payments, loans, or aid with no strings attached (Blanchard and Lu, 2012) and its huge market with business potential.

The existing research has shown two debates and one research gap concerning the resources of China's soft power. The first debate concerns whether the aforementioned possible cultural, diplomatic, and political attractions are effective in China's ongoing soft power promotion. The second is recent attempts to demarcate new indices of Chinese soft power but are mired in controversy of generalisability and practicality. The research gap is a paucity of in-depth empirical studies to explore and examine emerging resources of Chinese soft power, especially in the context of China's new foreign policies and initiatives for regional connectivity. While researchers have reached certain agreements on China's soft power resources within the three primary dimensions, most of them have built their arguments upon analyses of literature and documents only. Empirically based research has been very rare in the examination of possible emerging resources of China's soft power.



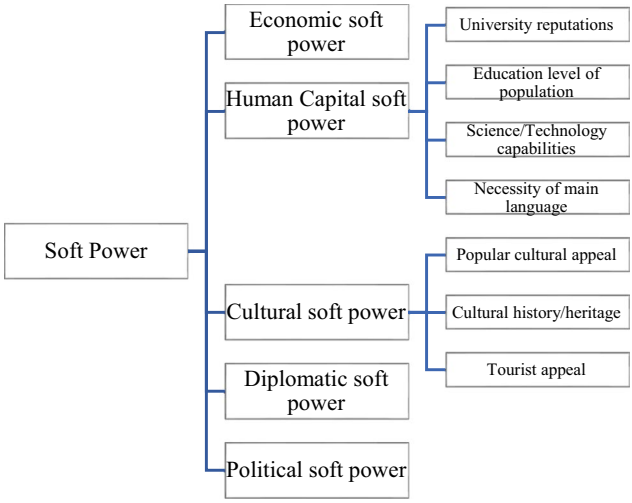
Source: Wojciuk *et al.* (2015)

Fig. 1 Educational soft power mechanisms.

Educational Soft Power

As part of the higher culture realm, education is an essential component of soft power (Nye, 2004). Particularly, among different levels of education, higher education is a crucial and influential soft power instrument for its role as a carrier of cultural and political values (Nye, 2005; Trilokeker, 2021; Wojciuk, 2018) and to project a state's soft power through 'winning hearts and minds' of foreign audiences, especially elites (Yang, 2007). Hence, a country's ideology might be propagated across the continents if enough international students have been educated in its universities (Hopf, 2013). Similarly, more effective higher education export might lead to more soft power gains. Along with the ongoing higher education internationalisation, modes of student and scholar mobility, cross-border educational services, and higher education internationalisation at home have proliferated. With tactful use of these potential educational soft power assets, it is possible to shape positive perceptions among international audiences, facilitate public diplomacy and transmission of the culture of the host country, and exert influence on future leaders of other states (Jain, 2018; Yang, 2007).

In recent years, especially with the heated discussion on the close connection between education and knowledge economy, higher education has been increasingly regarded as a powerful tool for broadening impact spheres (Stetar et al., 2010). Scholars start to conceptualise and operationalise educational soft power. Three pundits propose that three mechanisms, namely values, resources, and tools, react together to elaborate on how educational soft power works (see Fig. 1) (Wojciuk et al., 2015). First, resources stand for the eminence of education and the extent of educational internationalisation possessed by a country. Secondly, education transmits the values of a country to foreign audiences. If some values appeal to them, the soft power of a given country could be improved. Their analysis identifies the



Source: Holyk (2011)

Fig. 2 A model of soft power with education-related pillars.

quality of life and future potentiality as core values that boost the attraction. Finally, education is not only a source but also a tool for "achieving certain policy goals" (Wojciuk et al., 2015, 17).

In terms of operationalising educational soft power, Holyk (2011) compiles a model of soft power with five dimensions covering soft power deriving from economy, human resources, culture, foreign policy, and political ideology. Two of the above dimensions examine seven indices related to education, ranging from university prestige, schooling degree of population, science/technology capacities, and indispensability of first language in human capital dimension to contemporary culture appeal, traditional cultural heritage, and tourist attraction in cultural realm (see Fig. 2).

China's Soft Power in Higher Education

There are two forms of most discussed Chinese higher education institutions that purvey the values and culture to attract foreign audiences: establishing the CIs around the globe and hosting international students at home (Yang, 2007). A few early case studies indicate that CIs have been incorporated into the internationalisation of host universities in the West (Kwan, 2014; Yang, 2010), bringing mutual benefits to both countries. Other studies show that CIs are regarded as a threat to academic freedom and have largely failed to enhance China's soft power (Song, 2017; Zhou and Luk, 2016). China's engagement with Africa via CIs takes a form of cultural diplomacy to burnish its image, achieve its political and economic goals, and cultivate future leaders in line with Chinese values (Kragelund and Hampwaye,

2015; Wheeler, 2014). For Southeast Asia, several studies have presented the establishment process of CIs to reveal the dynamism of China's public diplomacy to promote its connectivity with ASEAN (Shuto, 2018; Theo and Leung, 2018; Thung, 2017).

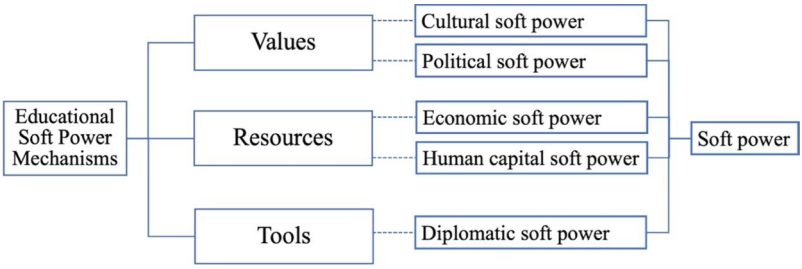
Compared with CIs, international students at home are a much less examined theme. Existing research has attempted to expound on the social, cultural, and learning experiences of international students in China, with findings suggesting that their majority have formed more favourable attitudes towards (Dong and Chapman, 2010; King, 2013) or at least obtained a better understanding of China (Mulvey, 2020). As for their learning experience, however, results illustrate some problems such as lack of student-faculty interaction, brand reputation deficit, insufficient quality assurance system, and weak English proficiency of lecturers, which hamper the cultural assimilation (Jain, 2018; Wen et al., 2018).

It is noteworthy that international students in China generally appreciate the scholarships offered to them by the Chinese government. With the newly announced BRI, more scholarships are expected at various levels from governments to companies and universities, in line with the growing cooperation between China and their countries of origin along the New Silk Road. Much more and deeper studies are called for to corroborate the corresponding influence on China's educational soft power.

To sum up, the research on China's soft power and higher education falls into gauging the aims and efficacy of China's soft power penetration, with a dearth of first-hand work on the recent changes in resources of Chinese soft power. A few recent empirical studies centre exclusively on the role of CIs (Jain, 2018; Song, 2017) or international students (Mulvey, 2020), or branch campuses (He and Wilkins, 2019). As China's higher education engagement with Southeast Asia is deeply involved in the current dynamics of China's soft-power praxis, it might be appropriate to probe into the current situation of Chinese soft power based on experiences and perceptions of participants from China's all-sided higher education outreach in this region. With reinforced economic links and people-to-people contacts under the recent BRI, how China has been doing and what this means in its soft-power terms deserve much further investigation. Empirical studies are particularly needed.

Theoretical Framework

This section justifies the analytical platform for this study, with an understanding that no theoretical framework has been agreed to be the best for research on soft-power resources. When Nye (2004, 2006) weighed in with the three soft power indices, he did not specify a model for the pillars and their interrelations. Huang and Ding (2006) expand the dimensions to culture, domestic values and policies, and substance and style of foreign policy. Holyk (2011) further proposes a five-dimension soft power model, including cultural, political, economic, human capital, and diplomatic soft power. economic and human capital soft power. Li and Worm (2011) develop a six-index conception of soft power with economic development model,



Source: Authors' own design based on Holy (2011) and Wojciuk *et al.* (2015)

Fig. 3 Educational soft power mechanisms and corresponding soft power pillars.

international image, and economic temptation as new resources. As for educational soft power, scholars explain how education generates soft power by attracting foreign audiences with academic excellence, transmitting values appealing to recipients, and serving as a diplomatic tool for moulding policy preferences (Wojciuk et al., 2015).

The educational soft power mechanism (Wojciuk et al., 2015) (see Fig. 1) is chosen to be combined with Holyk's (2011) five-dimension soft power model (see Fig. 2) to form the theoretical framework. First of all, most cultural and political values that education assists to diffuse are rooted in cultural and political soft power. Secondly, education itself is part of human capital soft power since human capital dimension encompasses university prestige, schooling degree of population, science/technology capacities, and indispensability of first language (Holyk, 2011). Thirdly, education, especially higher education, contributes significantly to economic soft power by building a knowledge economy (Peters, 2007). Furthermore, education, particularly higher education, could act as a tool in foreign policy to generate diplomatic soft power for a country (Wojciuk et al., 2015) (see Fig. 3). To explore changes in resources of soft power and identify new ones, the detailed index under each category of soft power as Holyk (2011) has suggested is not adopted here.

Based on the three mechanisms (values, resources, tools), China's educational soft power embedded in the experiences and perceptions of participants of Chinese higher education programs will be examined first. Next, according to the relationship between each mechanism and its corresponding resources of soft power, China's recent emerging resources of soft power in Southeast Asia will be analysed and discussed.

Methodology

This article intends to explore rather than quantify the experiences and perceptions of Cambodian students and professionals regarding their participation in Chinese higher education programs and how their reflections manifest resources of China's soft power in Southeast Asia. Therefore, qualitative research methodology was

selected to engender explanations from the context-specific observation (Bryman, 2012). Moreover, a case study approach stands out due to its advantages in yielding a thick description of focused contexts and scrutinising real-life events from interactions between researchers and participants (Yin, 2014). The case is defined as China's higher education engagement with Cambodia involving four kinds of practices in language training, student mobility, higher education development aid, and tertiary institution/program partnerships.

Cambodia was selected for four reasons. First, it holds geostrategic significance for China to expand its soft power in Southeast Asia. Second, with the recent infrastructure, business, and people-to-people projects initiated by BRI, China's economic, cultural, and political presence in Cambodia has been strengthened, which makes the exploration of changes in China's soft power sources both meaningful and feasible. Third, the aforementioned four main forms of China's higher education outreach to Southeast Asia could all be observed in Cambodia. Lastly, other ASEAN states might not be ideal choices. The Philippines and Vietnam have been caught up in the territorial disputes in the South China Sea. Previous violent riots targeting the Chinese diaspora in Malaysia and Indonesia have aggravated anti-Chinese sentiments (Welch, 2012). CI has not been established in Myanmar and Brunei. The researchers have no access to Chinese higher education programs in Thailand and Laos. Although China's higher education engagement with Singapore is active, it is mostly inward-oriented in that universities in Singapore enjoy a superior international reputation and academic performance.

Semi-structured interviews were utilised for data collection with respondents from diverse Chinese higher education programs. To gather first-hand information, one of the researchers conducted one-month fieldwork in Phnom Penh from May to June in 2019 to get in touch with alumni, current students, and local professionals. Another two field visits to Guangzhou and Shenzhen in mainland China were also accomplished later to interview Cambodian students on campus from July 2019 to February 2020. Purposive sampling was applied to ensure that interviewees either had served as leaders in China-Khmer higher education programs or participated in China-Khmer higher education programs as students or trainees or facilitators. The 40 interviewees include ten leaders of institution/program partnerships, seven insiders of China's higher education aid projects in Cambodia, seven members of CI, and sixteen Cambodian students from various disciplines of both elite and less renowned Chinese universities (see Table 1).

All 40 informants were interviewed in a one-to-one manner. Among them, 37 interviews were face-to-face while two were conducted via WeChat voice calls and one via messenger on Facebook depending on the informants' preferences. Hereinto, two graduates of Guangxi University were deliberately selected to uncover the role of "quiet achievers", the regional higher education institutions in less prosperous provinces adjacent to Southeast Asia (Yang, 2012, 488). Also, their earlier study experiences in China would serve as a contrast with other interviewees who were immersed in Chinese higher education programs in recent four years. Each interview lasted for about 40 minutes to one hour and was consisted of 11 open-ended questions related to values, resources, and tools as mechanisms of educational soft power. Yet, soft power resources were not directly asked but revealed through

Table 1 Interviewees' information

Informant	Institution	Location	Years Attended	Academic Programs	Scholarship
International students					
I 1	Peking University	Beijing	2016–2017	Public Administration	MOFCOM Scholarship
I 2	Tsinghua University	Beijing	2016–2018	Public Administration	MOFCOM Scholarship
I 3	Zhejiang University	Hangzhou	2019–present	Urban and Rural Planning	Government Scholarship
I 4	Zhejiang University	Hangzhou	2019–present	Civil Engineering	Government Scholarship
I 5	Tongji University	Shanghai	2017–2021	International Relations	Government Scholarship
I 6	SYU	Guangzhou	2017–2021	English Language	BRI Scholarship
I 7	SYU	Guangzhou	2017–2021	Chinese Language	BRI Scholarship
I 8	SYU	Guangzhou	2017–2019	Chinese Language	CI Scholarship
I 9	SCUT	Guangzhou	2018–present	International Trade	Government Scholarship
I 10	SCUT	Guangzhou	2016–2017	Chinese Language	CI Scholarship
I 11	SCNU	Guangzhou	2019–2020	Chinese Education	CI Scholarship
I 12	SUSTech	Shenzhen	2016–2020	Materials Science	University Scholarship
I 13	SUSTech	Shenzhen	2016–2020	Finance	University Scholarship
I 14	Guangxi University	Nanning	2012–2016	Construction Engineering	Government Scholarship
I 15	Guangxi University	Nanning	2013–2016	International Trade	Government Scholarship
I 16	NUIST	Nanjing	2014–2018	Computer Science	Government Scholarship
CI Students and faculty					
I 17	CI at Royal Academy of Cambodia	Phnom Penh	2019	College Student	
I 18	CI at Royal Academy of Cambodia	Phnom Penh	2019	High School Graduate	
I 19	Asia Euro University	Phnom Penh	2017-2021	College Student	
I 20	Asia Euro University	Phnom Penh	2017-2021	College Student	
I 21	Asia Euro University	Phnom Penh	2013-2017	College Student	

Table 1 (continued)

Informant	Institution	Location	Years Attended	Academic Programs	Scholarship
I 22	Confucius Institute at Royal Academy of Cambodia	Phnom Penh	2018-2020	Volunteer Teacher	
I 23	Asia Euro University	Phnom Penh	2017-2020	Director	
Participants of higher education aid programs					
I 24	RUPP	Phnom Penh	2016	Department Head	
I 25	RUPP	Phnom Penh	2017	Lecturer	
I 26	RUPP	Phnom Penh	2017&2018	Lecturer	
I 27	RUPP	Phnom Penh	2017	Lecturer	
I 28	RUPP	Phnom Penh	2015	Department Head	
I 29	Education Bureau	Phnom Penh	2018	Deputy Director	
I 30	University of Kratie	Kratie	2019-present	Lecturer	
Informants of higher education partnership programs					
I 31	CDRI	Phnom Penh	2015-present	Department Head	
I 32	Maritime Silk Road Research Centre	Phnom Penh	2017-present	Leadership	
I 33	Maritime Silk Road Research Centre	Phnom Penh	2017-present	Lecturer & Researcher	
I 34	RUPP	Phnom Penh	2017-present	Leadership	
I 35	RUPP	Phnom Penh	2018-present	Department Head	
I 36	RUPP	Phnom Penh	2011-present	Deputy Director	
I 37	RUPP	Phnom Penh	2016-present	Department Head	
I 38	Education Bureau	Phnom Penh	2015-present	Deputy Director	
I 39	Teacher College of Cambodia	Phnom Penh	2016-present	Leadership	
I 40	RUPP	Phnom Penh	2019-present	Lecturer & Researcher	

SYU is short for Sun Yat-sen University, SCUT for South China University of Technology, SCNU South for China Normal University, NUIST for Nanjing University of Information Science and Technology, RUPP for Royal University of Phnom Penh, CDRI for Cambodia Development and Research Institute

answers. With the interviewees' consent, the conversations were recorded and transcribed. Complementarily, documents were gathered from related academic articles, reports, news, and online websites of Ministry of Education of China (MOE), Ministry of Commerce of China (MOFCOM), and Chinese universities.

Findings and Discussion

This section elucidates major findings from fieldwork interviews, triangulated with document analysis. The data were analysed based on the proposed analytical framework (see Fig. 3) to explore the corresponding soft power resources of the educational soft power mechanism reflected in the interview answers. The evidence identifies four emerging resources of Chinese cultural, economic, human capital, and political soft power, namely contemporary life appeal, advancement in science and technology, STEM education reputation, and economic development model. BRI as a stimulus for emerging resources of Chinese soft power will also be discussed.

Contemporary Life Appeal

Interestingly and considerably contradictory to the findings from previous studies, contemporary life appeal, encapsulating a broader range of popular culture and an ideal of a good life, has emerged as a new resource of China's cultural soft power in Southeast Asia. For long scholars have claimed that popular culture is a weak pillar of Chinese soft power owing to the vagueness, ambiguity, and low popularity of cultural products (Gill and Huang, 2006). Lacking a clear image and without a coherent marketing strategy, China's contemporary culture could not compete with Hollywood filmmaking in the USA, ACG (animation, comic, game) in Japan, and K-Pop in South Korea. It has also been tagged with restrictions on social network media, 'made in China' fake products, and poor living conditions (Wen and Hu, 2018).

This study, however, finds that most respondents with recent studying or training or working experience in better-off cities in China have developed their appreciation of Chinese popular culture. Altogether 15 informants (I1, I3, I4, I6, I7, I8, I9, I10, I11, I13, I16, I17, I25, I27, I31) explicitly expressed their preference for China's contemporary life and modern society. One of them mentioned that she used to have a bad impression of China due to the outdated lifestyle of some Cambodians of Chinese descent. After staying in Shanghai to learn Chinese for one year, she admired the modern cities, people's values, and popular culture of China (I3). In particular, the convenient and fashionable lifestyle stands out as the main reason for them to enjoy their stay in China. The words like 'mobile payment' (WeChat Pay and Alipay), 'online shopping' (Taobao), 'high-speed rail', 'food delivery', and 'bike sharing' frequently appeared in their descriptions of China's contemporary culture and society. Other informants have already been interested in Chinese popular culture before they came to China. One male interviewee, for example, had even used Weibo for 6 years and watched every show of his Chinese idols on TV or Tencent video (I4). Most participants were fond of and accustomed to those new lifestyles

quickly. They sometimes even worry that they would not be able to get used to their lives back home where online services are not as widely and conveniently provided.

It seems that China's contemporary life appeal has grown with the blooming of e-commerce, e-finance, online technology, and other emerging industries. International news reports about the higher acceptability of Alibaba (China's e-commerce giant) in Southeast Asia further verify the potential role of the Internet economic culture in promoting contemporary China's cultural soft power (Qian, 2019). 2016-2017, 2018, and 2019 China National Image Global Survey in 22 countries, including Southeast Asian countries, also reported an obvious trend that China's Internet science-tech firms enjoyed a rise in popularity with Lenovo, Huawei, Alibaba, and Xiaomi topping the list (Academy of Contemporary China and World Studies, 2018, 2019, 2020).

In contrast, the attraction of China's cultural history heritage is not as evident. Only two interviewees mentioned traditional Chinese culture. One had been longing to study in China because of her interest in Chinese history, classic culture, and food described in high-school textbooks. Nevertheless, she later turned to like China's popular culture more than the traditional (I9). Another one is an ethnic Chinese with family education partly in terms of Chinese customs. After she had studied in Shenzhen for three years, she came to perceive that contemporary Chinese culture was featured with freedom and open-mindedness (I13). Overall, this study reminds us that the traditional-culture-oriented campaigns might not be the most effective approach to enhancing China's soft power. Chinese contemporary life attractiveness, as a significant part of popular culture, has become an entry point to purvey China's modern socio-cultural values among Southeast Asian recipients.

Advancements in Science and Technology

Since 2013, China's total R&D expenditure has been the world's second largest (National Bureau of Statistics of China, 2019) and rose to 310 billion US dollars in 2019 (National Bureau of Statistics of China, 2020). In 2016, China overtook the USA to become the largest producer of science and engineering publications (National Science Foundation, 2018). Throughout fieldwork, the authors were under the impression that China's advancement in science and technology appeared to be a predominant resource of the nation's human capital soft power. Once again, this challenges the findings from most previous studies that either regard China's science and technology capabilities as a negative factor (Wen and Hu, 2018) or do not find any obvious connection between scientific and technological developments in China and their influence on Chinese soft power growth (He and Wilkins, 2019). This study, however, confirms the conclusion of the Pew Research Global Attitudes Project (2013) that China's scientific and technological breakthroughs were the most appreciated aspect of Chinese soft power among less developed countries in Africa and Latin America.

Cambodian participants of Chinese higher education programs were clearly aware of China's scientific and technological development; 15 interviewees were impressed by the technology and innovation of China (I1, I3, I4, I5, I9, I12, I13, I16,

I24, I25, I26, I27, I29, I33, I34). They were also familiar with Chinese high-tech companies and products and even motivated to apply for enrolment in science and engineering programs or to establish cooperative research relationships with Chinese universities in science and technology fields. One respondent underlined that China could invent nearly all technologies on its own (I3). Another student found that China was investing a lot in research and development, and therefore, he could use plenty of sophisticated equipment in the school laboratories (I12). Particularly, four executive-level participants simultaneously stressed their hope to explore new forms or expand the existed platform of higher education partnership with Chinese universities in the field of science and engineering (I31, I32, I34, I37).

Although Cambodian faculty and students have been attracted by China's ascending performance in science and technology breakthroughs, Chinese universities, especially world-class ones, merely treat their MOUs with Cambodian universities as symbols of their internationalisation level or an icebreaker for tightening bilateral diplomatic relations instead of pathways to enhance Chinese soft power through solid research or education cooperative in science and engineering (I36, I37, I38). A member of the Royal University of Phnom Penh (RUPP) leadership team once expressed his doubts about Chinese universities' intentions to connect with Cambodian institutions:

> Most Chinese universities do not start any collaboration about science and technology. They ask RUPP to collaborate and to be the host. But besides hosting meetings, there is no progress. They do not go to our university to meet with our people…Some Chinese universities they signed MOUs with us and only wanted to send students for a short exchange in Cambodia. But we do not have enough classrooms. They do not think about their partners usually but only stick to their own agenda. (I34)

STEM Education Reputation

The rapid development of science and technology and impressive performances of Chinese universities in international rankings have combined to contribute to the growing visibility of Chinese STEM education. Nearly all interviewees specialising in STEM acknowledged the Chinese higher education reputation as a significant pull factor and spoke highly of the STEM programs on Chinese campuses (I3, I4, I12, I16, I I24, I25, I26, I27, I29). Three undergraduates explicitly mentioned that they were inclined to apply for STEM programs due to the latest outstanding achievements of Chinese institutions in global rankings of academic subjects (I2, I3, I4). Times Higher Education World University Rankings 2021 by Subject put Peking University 9th in engineering, surpassing the National University of Singapore, Imperial College London, and Yale University. Tsinghua University ranked 10th in QS World University Rankings by Subject 2017-2019: Engineering and Technology. It moved up to 9th in 2020, beyond Harvard University, California Institute of Technology, and University of Tokyo.

One informant had already studied at the Institute of Technology of Cambodia for one year, the best science and technology university in Cambodia, but chose to go

to Zhejiang University for a better education experience in the engineering program (I3). Another student even gave up his two-year schoolwork in a Cambodian higher education institution and applied to Zhejiang University because of its higher ranking in Civil Engineering subject (I4). A Tsinghua University alumnus remarked that 'Tsinghua is one of best universities around the world. Its engineering and science are the best ranked in the world' (I2).

The Chinese government and universities are making efforts to captivate more international talents. For example, two informants mentioned that they had firstly undertaken a one-year program at Tongji University. The curriculum was tailored for STEM international students by encompassing Chinese classes and foundation courses, which eased the language barrier for future studies (I3, I16). In general, the proportion of overseas enrolments in China in science and engineering programs has increased from 8.55% in 2008 to 16.69% in 2018 while the rate of international students in Chinese language programs decreased from 55.74% to 37.68%.[2] This is a new development from the previous situation that Chinese higher education had not been conducive to the enhancement of its international influence because international students in China concentrated extremely on Chinese language programs (Kuroda, 2014). A latest survey results based on 1,450 current international enrolments also corroborate the argument of this study. They reported that international African and Asian students in China have patronised STEM majors, with Engineering subject topping the list, whereas more American and European students in China have flowed into social science disciplines (Obed et al., 2020).

Compared with elite universities or universities of science and technology in well-off cities, less prestigious universities in economically underdeveloped areas seemingly do not possess much STEM attraction. Among all interviewed students and trainees majoring in STEM, only one informant who graduated from Guangxi University in 2016 did not speak highly of his academic experience in China (I14). Yet, China's regional universities in Southwestern provinces bordering Southeast Asia still have much to offer in spreading China's influence in the region (Yang, 2012). Another Guangxi University graduate, for example, referred to the close partnership between Cambodia and Guangxi, rather than the university reputation, as the main reason for him to come to study in China (I15). In 2017, 14,500 international students were studying in Guangxi, and no less than 65% of them were from ASEAN countries, which tripled the size within the past decade (Ministry of Education of China, 2018).

Notably, for participants who have majored in non-STEM disciplines, the recognition of Chinese higher education quality is quite minimal. Two students mentioned that the English language proficiency of instructors sometimes would hinder them from fully comprehending the content of English-medium classes (I9, I13). This result echoes an earlier survey, in which international students who were taught in

[2] The proportions of overseas enrolments in China in science and engineering programs in 2008 and in 2018 are based on authors' own calculation with the data retrieved from *Statistics Book of International Students Studying in China* (in Chinese) (Department of International Cooperation and Exchanges of Ministry of Education of China, 2008, 2018).

English at eight Chinese universities reported significantly lower satisfaction with the overall learning experience (Wen et al., 2018). Another non-STEM graduate recalled that teachers of specialised courses usually repeated what the PowerPoint said (I15). Even a few students from STEM programs still had difficulties in getting accustomed to the spoon-feeding classroom and rote-learning oriented evaluation (I12, I16). It seems that the inadequate student–faculty interaction (Wen et al., 2018) and passive pedagogy (Liu, 2017) would lower the quality of Chinese higher education programs, impairing the soft power outcomes hence (Wojciuk, 2018).

Implications of China's Development Model

As Western political discourse continues to dominate the world, it is hard for China to break through the assumption that democracy and liberty are naturally more appreciated than stability and prosperity (Barker, 2017). Chinese researchers and policymakers used to be worried that fears about China threat would be fuelled if the development model is exported abroad (Glaser and Murphy, 2008). Nevertheless, this study uncovers that China's development model, especially its economic paradigm, has indeed attracted much attention worldwide, especially from developing countries. Three groups of Cambodian informants, namely leadership, CI students, and students studying/studied in China, all consciously referred to China's development model without any hint from the investigators.

When asked about the expectation for future collaboration with China in higher education, the vice-chancellor of RUPP unhesitatingly responded: 'the first is about two-sided cooperation. The second is about China Model, including economy, education, infrastructure, all about contemporary China' (I34). The director of Maritime Silk Road Research Centre was more explicit about the possible collaborative forms in terms of China's development model. He explained that:

> I think Cambodia actually admires Shenzhen's developmental trajectory and aspires to imitate what has been doing in Shenzhen. The (Sihanoukville) special economic zone is trying to implement Shenzhen Development, a special case of Chinese development model, in Cambodia and in the context of BRI. (I32)

Additionally, the establishment of the Institute of South-South Cooperation and Development (ISSCAD) might be a step forward to construct China's political soft power among officials from developing countries. Based at Peking University, ISSCAD was announced by President Xi Jinping in 2015. It aims to share the successful development experience of China and other developing countries with mid-level to senior officials, managers, and researchers from developing countries. One ISSCAD graduate thought it was common-sense among Cambodian officials that China and Cambodia share many similarities in politics. 'Cambodia now is walking like China did thirty years ago', he said. As a government official, he applied for the master's program at Peking University when he was informed about the MOFCOM Scholarship, which sponsors young and middle-aged talents from recipient countries to pursue their postgraduate education in China since 2015. He also spoke highly of the

curriculum offered by ISSCAD, particularly seminars tailored for them to introduce China's experience of economic and social development (I1). However, China's higher education and policy elites have much to do to theorise the Chinese model and effectively demonstrate its significant global implications, particularly for the vast developing sphere.

BRI as a stimulus

Southeast Asia has long been the major target of China's Maritime Silk Road Initiative. New institutions financing the BRI projects in Southeast Asia, including the Silk Road Fund (40 billion US dollars), the China-ASEAN Investment Cooperation Fund (10 billion US dollars), and the multilateral Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (100 billion US dollars), have been established. The total infrastructure investments approximately reach at least 1 trillion US dollars (Hillman, 2018). In 2017, it was estimated that 45% of Chinese BRI projects were assigned to Southeast Asia (Lubin *et al*., 2018).

Under the auspices of BRI, possible economic benefits brought by massive investments and tremendous trade volume have further stimulated local people's interest in China (I2, I31, I32, I33, I34, I38). Without any hint from the researchers, 17 informants (I6, I7, I9, I11, I12, I13, I19, I20, I21, I22, I23, I31, I32, I33, I34, I38, I39) mentioned their knowledge of or viewpoints on BRI. One obvious phenomenon includes that an increasing number of students from BRI partner countries have entered Chinese campuses. It was reported that 52.95% of overseas students enrolled in Chinese institutions were from the BRI partner countries in 2018 (Ministry of Education of China, 2019). Two interviewees were recipients of the BRI scholarship. According to them, the BRI had generated numerous job vacancies in Cambodia as more Sino-Cambodian projects and corporations were formed (I6, I7). Two participants were founding members of the Maritime Silk Road Research Centre at RUPP. The research centre received part of the initial fund from the Embassy of China in the Kingdom of Cambodia to carry on international relations studies in the context of regional connectivity after the commencement of BRI (I32, I33).

While part of Southeast Asian students was wooed by traditional resources of China's soft power, namely language necessity and economic temptation, many others have started to change their perceptions about China's contemporary culture, science, and technology capability, higher education prestige, and even tried to bring China's experience of development back to their home countries. For example, one respondent planned to work in China to learn business models and then start up her own company back in Cambodia (I13). Another one always observed how China had planned and developed cities when travelling around as she thought Cambodians would have much to learn from (I3).

Remarkably, BRI might serve as a powerful vehicle to universalise Beijing's development path in latecomer countries. With the intensified economic interaction and infrastructure connectivity, Cambodian officials and professionals had been expressing strong interest in higher education exchange or partnership programs that could allow them to draw lessons from the successful development experiences of

China (I1, I32, I34, I38). Chinese governments of all levels and enterprises work closely with their counterparts in BRI countries to launch projects based on economic and social development paradigms with Chinese characteristics. The going-out of China's special economic zone model might be employed as a vivid case. The Urban Planning and Design Institute of Shenzhen (2019) reported on its website that requested by the Ministry of Economy and Finance of Cambodia, it has conducted a feasibility study on building Sihanoukville Special Economic Zone (SSEZ) following the Shenzhen experience. SSEZ was consequently established patterned after Shenzhen Special Economic Zone and became a landmark project of BRI.

Concluding Remarks

Through a first-hand investigation into the interplay between educational soft power mechanisms and corresponding soft power sources, four emerging resources of China's soft power in Southeast Asia have been identified: contemporary life appeal, science and technology capabilities, STEM education reputation, and China's economic development model. To some extent, their emergence could have been anticipated. First, they are tightly related to the economic power status of China. Soft power is not isolated from representational power (Mattern, 2005). The enhanced economic significance of China has expedited its ascent as a country of economic temptation, attracting more foreign audiences to inquire about its society, culture, education, and development experiences. Meanwhile, the BRI serves as a powerful catalyst to further deepen the influence of China's economic power and diffuse its soft power in the regional arena (Beeson, 2018). Lastly, they interrelate and enhance each other. The ascending research competence of Chinese universities upgrades the regional innovation system (Chen and Kenney, 2007) and then the national science and technology capabilities. China's remarkable achievements in R&D break the fault line of its economic development model, enhance its contemporary life appeal, and contribute to its university reputation in return.

For China to win in the global soft power competition, challenges are many in both scale and intensity. Domestic coordination of different players and an ideal mix of resources have not been formulated (Gill and Huang, 2006). The spectre of a Rising China is still haunting the Western-led world. While authors have pointed out various limitations of the notion of soft power (Ferguson, 2003; Hall, 2010), we find it particularly limited in the interpretation of China's global role as a 'civilisation-state' (Jacques, 2012). Based on a linear mode of thinking, it is from a negative, dichotomous, zero-sum, and competition angle (Suzuki, 2009). It assumes that China's rising power would inevitably lead to conflicts (Yang, 2018), but neglects the influence of Chinese values like 'harmony-with-diversity' and 'Great Harmony' (Callahan, 2012). Evaluating China solely grounded on the Western lexicon fails to properly comprehend China's originality and possibility in China's own terms (Xia, 2014). A thorough interpretation of China's recent initiatives calls for more sophisticated perspectives to complement the soft power lens.

If Beijing determines to demonstrate a harmonious world order different from the Western dominance to consolidate its soft power in Southeast Asia, it should

not only depend on economic and infrastructure initiatives. Otherwise, its enhanced economic presence in Southeast Asia would be regarded as another attempt to forge a Sino-centric order rather than a catalyst for its soft power. Solid people-to-people connectivity based on genuine understanding and respect of local socio-cultural contexts is a must. There is a lack of concrete and sustainable higher education programs between China and the latecomer countries of ASEAN. Although elites might be aware of the emerging soft power attractions when they are deeply immersed in Chinese higher education programs, the vast local people still hold a relatively indifferent or even negative impression of modern China (I31). Higher education engagement with local stakeholders should play a more pragmatic part in future practices that China and Southeast Asian countries could mutually benefit from. China's emerging soft power resources suggested in this study and non-state actors such as e-commerce and short-video giants need to be integrated into a systematic strategy for Beijing's soft power campaign.

This study has implications for policymakers and China observers on the recent dynamics of China's soft power in Southeast Asia. By exploring participants' experiences in view of the proposed analytical framework, it offers a unique prism from the educational soft power to detail the occurring changes in resources of China's soft power. It endorses the role of Chinese contemporary life featured by non-governmental sectors such as e-commerce, technological applications, and universities. It also checks the effectiveness of China's current soft power mechanisms and campaigns. More studies related to educational soft power are certainly needed to further examine the effectiveness of the proposed model.

Since Cambodian participants of Chinese higher education programs in this study mainly are elites, their experiences and perceptions could not fully represent the overwhelming majority of local people. It is noteworthy that China's emerging soft power resources might exert very limited influence on the non-elite. For indigenous Khmer who have never visit China in person, their impressions of China either still stay in the past or have been negatively affected by the Chinese workers, gamblers, and small merchants that they are exposed to in daily life (I31). With a single country as the case, this article also has clear limitations in terms of generalisability and reliability. Further comparative research on possible emerging resources of China's soft power in other Southeast Asian countries is needed. The changing status of influence from emerging sources identified here, and other resources including shared norms and values, mutual benefits of tourism, and ethnic Chinese communities (Percival, 2007) also deserve further investigation on the challenges and opportunities for both China and Southeast Asia to foster truly reciprocal interrelationships.

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Declarations

Conflict of interest On behalf of all authors, the corresponding author states that there is no conflict of interest.

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